

BACKGROUND ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL COUNCIL

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Introduction

"Overcoming Technology Segregation: Addressing Economic Inequality in the Access to Innovations."

Greetings, delegates, the Economic and Social Council Chair welcomes you to the 16th edition of the Model of the United Nations Instituto Oriente 2026.

This United Nations Model represents a valuable opportunity for you, as a delegate, to strengthen essential skills such as working under pressure, debate, critical thinking and time management. Our job, as your Chair, is to guide and support the delegates through this model, providing them with the tools and assistance necessary to ensure a good debating experience and the creation of accurate, realistic and workable solutions for the world.

We, as the Chair, are confident that dedication and discipline will help to perform excellently in debating and creating innovative solutions, not only within the model, but also in daily life.

This topic was chosen by the Chair due to the importance that technology has acquired in the global economy, defining whether a country has the capacity to grow or not. It is undeniable that the United Nations Economic and Social Council must evaluate and propose recommendations in order to balance the market and allow all countries to compete in the creation and implementation of these new technologies in order to improve the quality of life of their inhabitants, based on their resources and in a sustainable long-term manner.

Delegates, in order to discuss the topic **"Overcoming Technology Segregation: Addressing Economic Inequality in the Access to Innovations."** and to ensure clarity and accuracy, we, as an international committee, would benefit from further contextual information

Technological segregation could be defined as the gap between developed and developing countries in access to and development of new technologies that can improve the quality of life of their inhabitants.

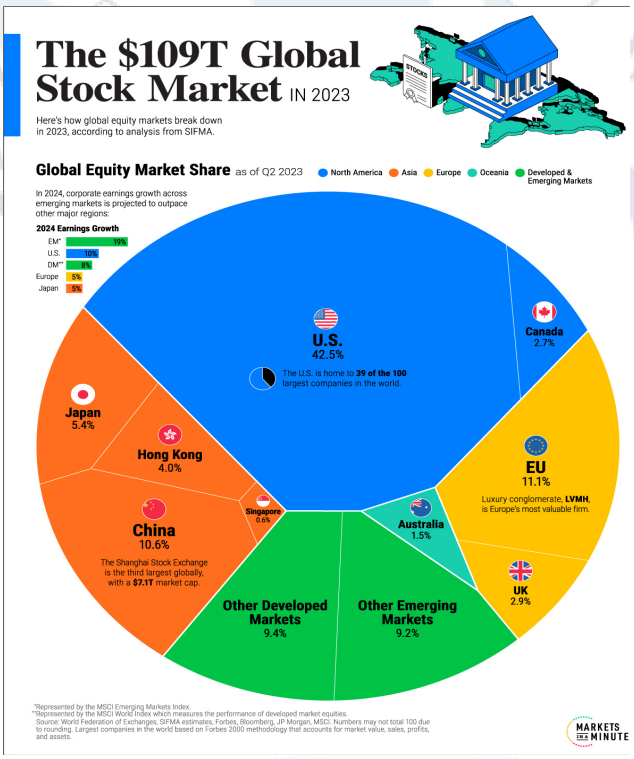
Over the past few years the digital divide has been reduced considerably, but even in 2024, 2.6 billion people, which represent approximately one-third of the world's population, remained without internet access. Preventing people from being left behind in the first

place is more effective than trying to catch them up later. There are moral and business benefits in building an inclusive internet owing to the necessity that being digitally connected represents in order to be part of the society and have access to crucial services, such as digital banking, telemedicine and online education.

Information technology stocks constitute the largest sector in the S&P 500, accounting for over 30% of the index's value. However, developing countries contribute only 20% of this share, China being the owner of a big piece of it. This is reflected in the inability of developing countries to compete significantly in this critically important market.

Developing countries are often characterized by weak business regulations, which, compounded by systemic corruption, create an environment conducive to exploitation. Foreign entities frequently exploit these regulatory weaknesses, committing labor abuses and extracting natural resources with little oversight. Furthermore, the lack of robust legal safeguards for local populations perpetuates this cycle of inequality, leaving them disproportionately vulnerable to external exploitation and economic subjugation.

Throughout this document you, as a delegate, will find helpful information that can be useful in the debate. In the document there are causes and consequences, controversial points, the objective of the committee, how the problem affects developed and developing countries, the risks they run and sources of further information.



History of the Committee

Creation of the United Nations

The United Nations is an international organization founded on October 24, 1945 by 51 countries around the world, its main objective is to maintain peace, security and improve the quality of life of people around the world through the pursuit and promotion of human rights. Over the years more members have been added, currently it has 193 members.

Creation of the Economic and Social Council

In 1945, the United Nations recognized the need to address economic and social issues at an international level. As a result, they created a main body in charge of these aspects called the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), having its first meeting in January 1946 in London. Since then, the committee has served as the basis for the United Nations to address issues with the above-mentioned aspects.

Purpose of the Economic and Social Council

Its main objective is to improve the quality of life of people around the world, through the support of its subsidiary bodies, covering economic, social and environmental aspects.

Function of the Economic and Social Council

The Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) has the responsibility of coordinating the work of the United Nations and discussing economic and social issues, supporting sustainable development, promoting human rights and encouraging the participation of non-governmental organizations.

In essence, the role of the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) is to be an intermediary for the world, serving as a space for dialogue and debate with the aim of finding solutions. By being open to the world, it has involved politicians, parliamentarians, academics, foundations, businesses, youth and registered non-governmental organizations (NGOs).

Problems facing the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

Like all United Nations organs, the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) is charged with debating and confronting different issues each year in order to find a viable and safe solution for all.

Here are some of the obstacles that the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) is reviewing this year.

- Financing Universal Healthcare in Developing Countries
    - Discuss international cooperation and financial mechanisms to achieve universal health coverage in low-income countries

- The question of Economic Inequality on Public Health
    - The search for why economic inequalities are one of the main causes of the health gap and what policies can reduce the health inequality between people with high and low economic levels.

- Strengthening Health Systems in Post-Conflict Regions
    - How countries emerging from armed conflict can rebuild their health systems, focusing primarily on sustainable infrastructure and staff development.

"Let us work together to fulfill ECOSOC's mandate to respond to the world's greatest challenges"
Munir A. (2021) Ex President of the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)



Long term

Over the past two decades, technology has become a fundamental part of humanity's daily existence like never before, serving as a pillar of communication by facilitating interactions between users worldwide and playing a key role in addressing various economic, medical, social, and scientific challenges. Given its profound relevance, the underdevelopment of technology in low-income areas creates a considerable gap between nations, reaching extremes that interfere with a country's progress and, consequently, the fulfillment of human rights.

The global market of the Internet has grown significantly, but since their inception caused a large economic and class gap in many countries:

- The Internet in 2004 moved about 150 billion dollars thanks to the use made of it by people on different websites. Only 12% of the world's population had access to the Internet, most of which is concentrated in developed countries, on the other hand in several rural regions of Asia, Africa and much of Latin America it could be accessed through an Internet cafe or not even had at all. This demonstrates that the opportunity gap in different countries is becoming increasingly noticeable, affecting populations in different countries in different ways.

- In 2014, the Internet moved approximately 1.5 billion dollars, mainly due to the rise of its major platforms, since for this year the use of the Internet represented 40% of the world population, the biggest difference with 2004 was not the access, but the quality. In developed countries there was a great improvement, the 4G network was expanding, while in developing countries there were only 3G networks.

Having in mind the capacity that all these digital technologies have taken over the past few years, it is undeniable that tech companies can take advantage of the increasing gap. A notable example is Facebook's 2016 initiative, Free Basics, a program launched in India and Africa to provide "free internet", but with limited access to websites that were not related to Facebook or their partners, creating a restricting access to external platforms, effectively monopolizing user traffic. India banned this program in the same year calling it "digital colonialism" demonstrating the vulnerability of developing countries to large private corporations with significant technological influence.

Medical technologies represent one of the most important advancements for humanity, improving the quality of life, and transforming healthcare systems worldwide. However, their rapid development has also highlighted significant technological divergence between nations, creating a divide between those who can afford it and those who cannot.

Medical technologies are divided into three branches: medical devices , which sales increased from $90 million in 2004 to $180 million in 2014, due to growing global demand; diagnostic equipment, these sales doubled from $50 billion in 2004 to $100 billion in 2014, with Magnetic Resonance Imaging's sales alone surging by 120% over that decade; and digital technologies, which, though emerging with $5 billion in sales in 2004, experienced a staggering 500% growth by 2014, reaching $30 billion in sales.

Even though all this growth was due to all the countries that contributed to its use and creation, there were many countries that could not make significant contributions, increasing the current gap for many sub-Saharan and Western Asia countries.

In 2004, the United States of America and Europe dominated this market by 80%, unlike Asia and Latin America, which only managed to dominate 15% of the market. In 2014 the United States of America and Europe only controlled 70%, countries like China and India got 20% of this market for their investment in hospitals.

The technological gap that was most noticeable was the contrast between the quality of the equipment used in developed countries that adopted robotics, such as Da Vinci and Electronic Health Record's, while the developing countries depended on donations and second hand equipment.

Developing countries are increasingly dependent on developed countries in many areas, and there is a growing risk that they will be left behind on the world stage and be the most affected in global emergencies, as they are unable to be self-sufficient or protect themselves. The United Nations is seeking alternatives to enable all states to be self-sufficient and have the same importance as everyone else on a global level.

Short term

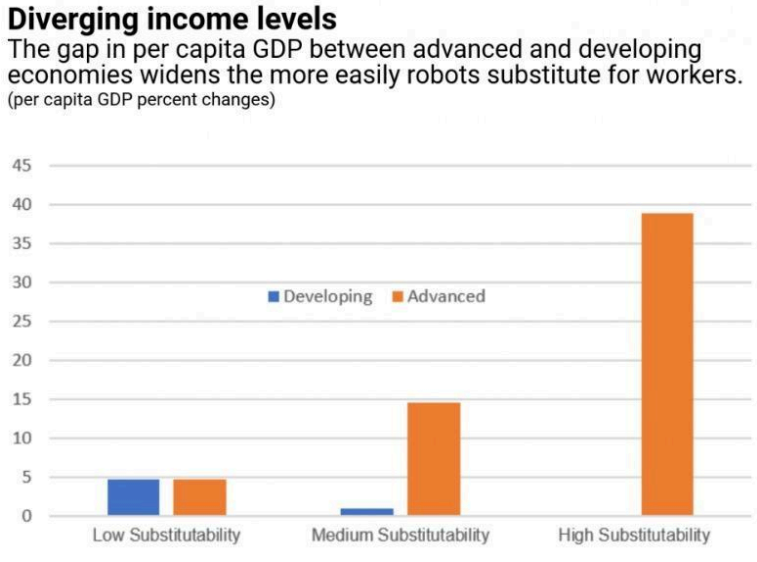
Over the years, technology has come a long way, becoming a fundamental part of ongoing advances in education, medicine, science, artificial intelligence, communications, robotics, quantum technology, and biotechnology.

People who can access these services benefit from being able to perform complex actions in a simpler way and have a better quality of life. On the other hand, those who cannot access them are disadvantaged, causing exclusion from accessing basic services.

However, the risk of exclusion has also increased. While technology advances further and allows others to progress, those unable to access its benefits remain left behind. It is worth noting that developing countries are primarily excluded from the global landscape due to their political and economic instability and lack of resources.

Recently, several sectors have experienced technological growth. This growth has also widened the gap in fields, such as:

- **Artificial intelligence:** Although this new type of technology can currently revolutionize industrial processes, it is a threat for developing countries since investments would only be made where processes are already consolidated.



The consequences for developed countries would be that they could automate their industrial processes, save money on wages and invest it in the productivity of the robots, obtaining more profits and attracting investment in the short term.

On the other hand, the consequences for the developing countries would be not to generate interest in investments

because they are not modernized, forcing them to do so at the cost of laying off a large number of workers, the problem is that many of these countries depend directly on the labor force.

- **Communications:** Devices with internet access, facilitate human communication regardless of the distance, but not everyone has access to these devices, either by isolation, lack of resources, government orders or armed conflicts. The result is that many people are cut off from others and isolated from everything that happens in their environment and globally.

  States around the world have warned that as developed countries eliminate old communication networks to work with more modern networks such as 5G leaving behind the developing nations because they cannot deploy such modern networks due to lack of economic resources, this added to the fact that only 36% of the population of developing countries use the Internet really worries governments because it is increasingly noticeable that there is a technological, social and economic lag to access services that today are indispensable.

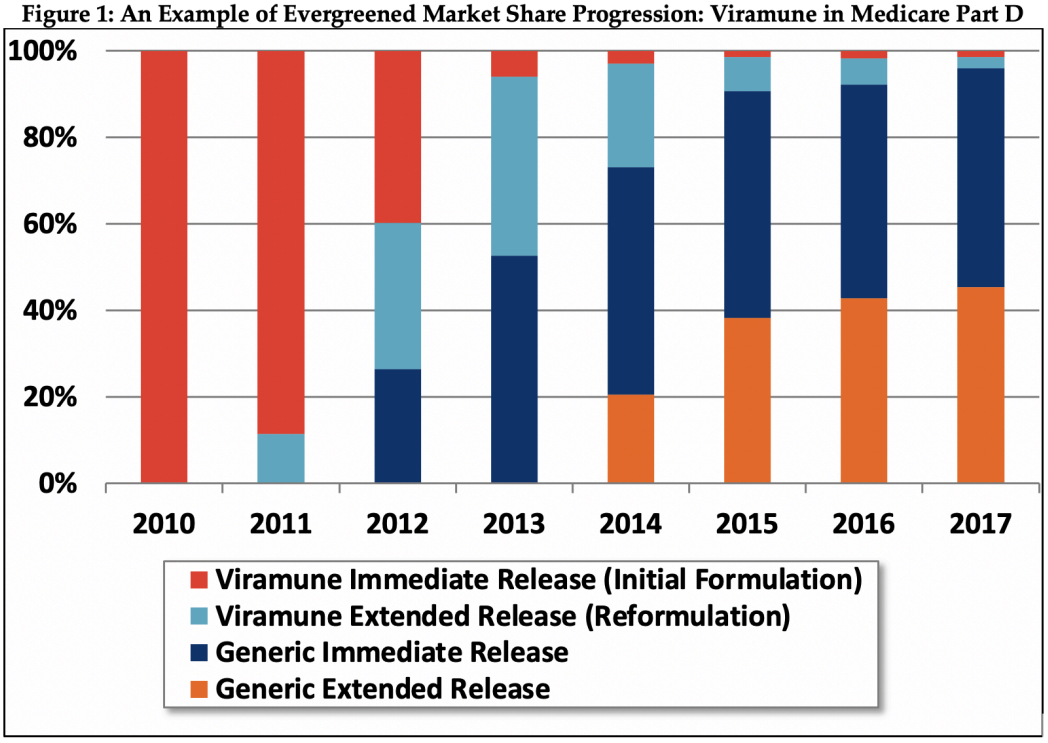
- **Medicine:** In most developed countries, it has been possible to innovate and implement new technologies to take care and extend the life expectancy of the elderly, while in the developing countries there are still various problems that leave the populations too vulnerable to deadly diseases.

  The most recent evidence of how this gap can affect countries is the Ebola outbreak in West Africa during the winter of 2014 and summer of 2016 where the United States of America, the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, and the Republic of France had to send medical and military personnel, as personnel from the affected countries did not know how to use medical equipment or how to detect the virus.

  Another proof was the outbreak of Cholera in the Republic of Yemen where the lack of medical infrastructure and the knowledge to know how to operate the equipment stretched from 2016 to the end of 2021 but due to pandemic complications the help was minimal. This provided that the technological gap that exists in the different health systems can make them depend on countries that do have technology to treat serious diseases, but if these states can not help the population of the affected country will suffer for many years because their nation is not able to stop a disease of such magnitude.

Brand drug manufacturers employ various evergreening strategies to perpetuate monopolies, such as strategically timing line extensions to exploit FDA supplemental approvals that grant three-year exclusivity for reformulations, thereby delaying clinically beneficial versions while stifling competition, as seen with HIV drug Viramune, whose 2011 ER launch preserved brand dominance despite 2012 IR generic entry, costing Medicare an estimated $59 million in excess spending and likely more in commercial markets, this kind of policies demonstrate the urgent necessity to renovate the current policies that exclude the vulnerable groups to access to health.

Figure 1: An Example of Evergreened Market Share Progression: Viramune in Medicare Part D



Topic and the United Nations

The United Nations has repeatedly addressed certain issues in order to find viable solutions for all countries through various committees. It has emphasized that everyone must tackle the problem to prevent it from advancing and that international cooperation is needed to improve the world as a whole, such as:

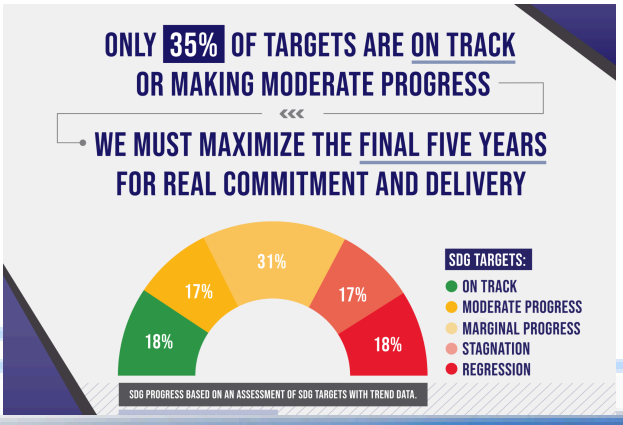
Sustainable Development Goals (2030 agenda)

In this document, the members of the United Nations have declared that in order to close the technological gap, they must make greater efforts in two areas:

1. Industry, innovation, and infrastructure: Investing in infrastructure can bring economic benefits, as it promotes the growth of new industries and the development of new information and communication technologies, enabling the creation of new jobs and the promotion of these new types of technology, enabling local and foreign investment for industrial and scientific purposes.

2. Reducing inequalities: the United Nations has stated that if it is necessary, discriminatory laws and policies must be eliminated to ensure equal opportunities through inclusion. Each state must take responsibility for these policies, as they are obstacles to achieving goal number 10 of the 2030 agenda. Countries must not only eliminate these barriers but also integrate marginalized communities to foster unity.

Some solutions to end income inequality include regulating markets, encouraging foreign direct investment in regions of great need, facilitating safe migration, and encouraging official development assistance, including foreign direct investment aligned with national programs. Also having in mind the urgency of these goals and their importance and how there are aspects that need to be reinforced.



United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization's Recommendation on Open Science (2021)

Based on Article 27 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which establishes the right of everyone to participate in scientific progress and its benefits. This document seeks to broaden access to scientific and technological knowledge, contributing directly to reducing the digital divide with the following measures:

1. Promote public and open access to scientific knowledge, ensuring that all scientific research and data are unrestricted by paywalls, geography, or institutional barriers.

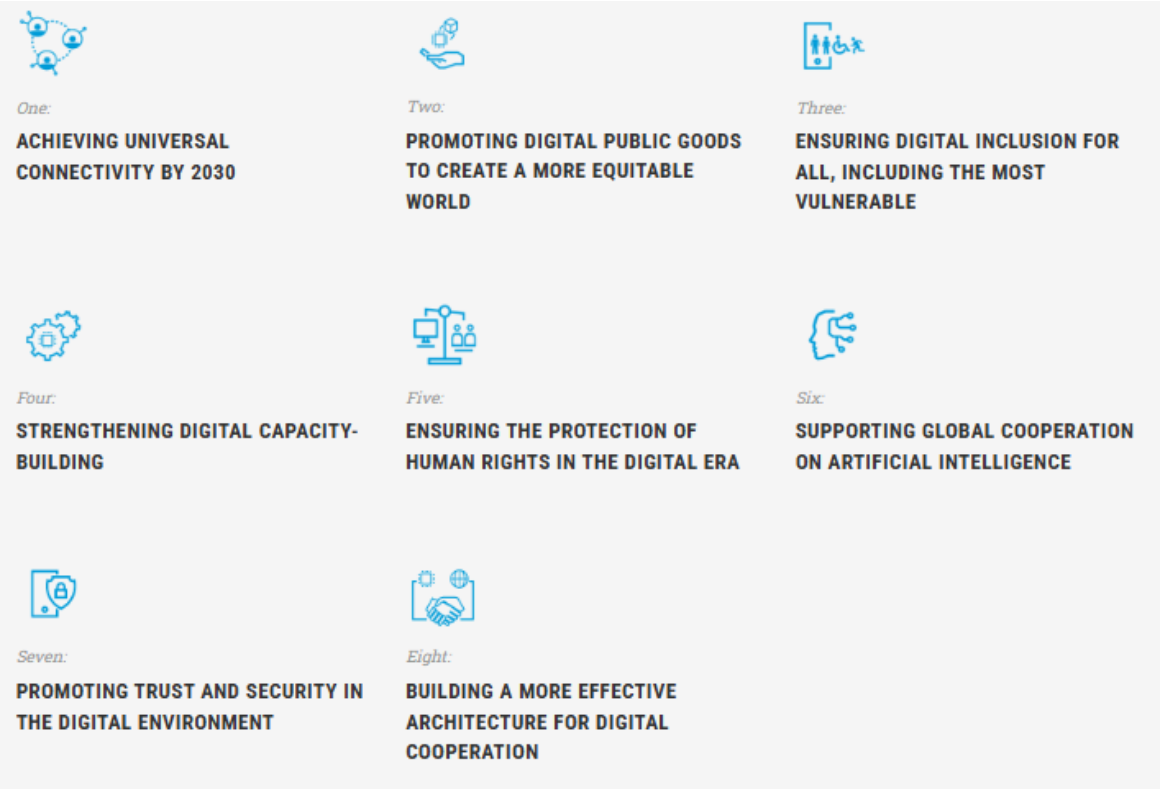
2. Create a more inclusive digital infrastructure, encouraging the use of free software, to avoid dependence on high-cost private programs.

3. Develop training in digital skills, so that people who barely have access to these technologies learn to use them, all thanks to massive courses.

UN Digital Cooperation Roadmap

In June 2020, the General Assembly created an international program with the aim of promoting cooperation among United Nations members, sharing information and knowledge, and supporting each other to close the technology gap. The United States of America, the People's Republic of China, and the members of the European Union are key members of this program. In recent years, one of the advances shared by this program has been regulations on information protection.

Based on recommendations from the Secretary-General's High-level Panel for Digital Cooperation convened from 2018-2019, and further informed by a series of roundtable discussions with key stakeholders from Governments, the private sector, civil society, international organizations, academic institutions, the technical community, and other relevant stakeholders, the following set of actions are envisaged:



The Alliance for Affordable Internet

The Alliance for Affordable Internet is a global coalition led by the Web Foundation that works to reduce the digital divide through policies and practices to make internet access more affordable, implementing this measures to prevent technological segregation:

1. Promote regulatory reforms to pressure governments to eliminate excessive taxes on digital devices and services.

2. Support community networks in rural areas, currently there are projects in Brazil and India with low-cost internet networks and alliances with Google and Facebook to increase digital infrastructure in remote areas.

Controversy points

Why is this topic controversial?

Overcoming technological segregation and addressing economic inequality in access to innovations are controversial issues, as they are connected with deep ideological divisions over the role of government, corporate transparency, and human rights. The debate is further complicated by concerns about privacy and surveillance, fears of corporate monopolies, geopolitical tensions between nations vying for technological dominance and citizens without access to new technologies may be deprived of basic rights and disadvantaged in an increasingly technology-dependent world. Furthermore, disagreements arise over who should bear the costs. Should it be governments, businesses, or individuals? Does expanding access address underlying economic disparities or merely serves as a temporary fix? These conflicting perspectives on equity, economic philosophy, and the balance between public and private control make the issue deeply contentious.

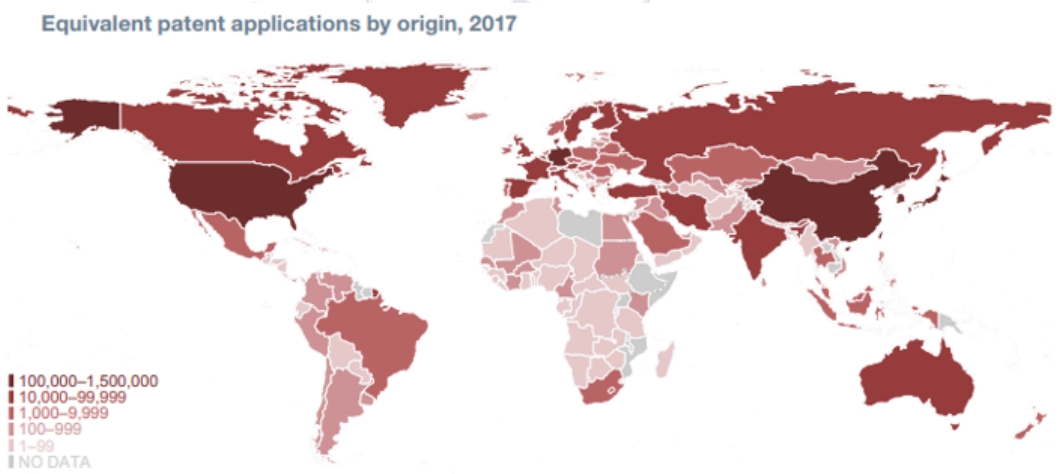
What positions are in the topic?

Some countries, such as India and South Africa, argue that access to technology is a fundamental need today, requiring policy interventions, subsidies to ensure equitable distribution, and training in these new technologies for all. However, countries such as the United States, the United Kingdom, and Singapore oppose this stance, arguing that the market should dictate access, fearing that if scientists cannot fully benefit from their work, their motivation will decline, resulting in a decrease in production across all industries. On the other hand, countries such as China, Russia, Iran, and Belarus restrict public access to technology, prioritizing digital control and censorship. Despite their technological advancements, they limit access in the name of national security, often using surveillance and social control tools.

Why is there a debate?

Technological segregation extends beyond the development gap between nations; it stems from monopolistic practices, corporate taking advantage of legal frameworks, and inefficient economic policies in countries facing more immediate crises. The debate is about where to draw the line between being able to profit from hard-won scientific knowledge and abusing patents that may be decades old. As a committee focused on economics, we cannot ignore these gaps that

perpetuate inequality between classes and countries in a world where technology is needed every day and is still treated a privilege instead of an enabling right, like water and electricity, for this reason organizations such as the United Nations already consider the Internet as a human right, but its implementation around the world stills inconsistent.



Objective

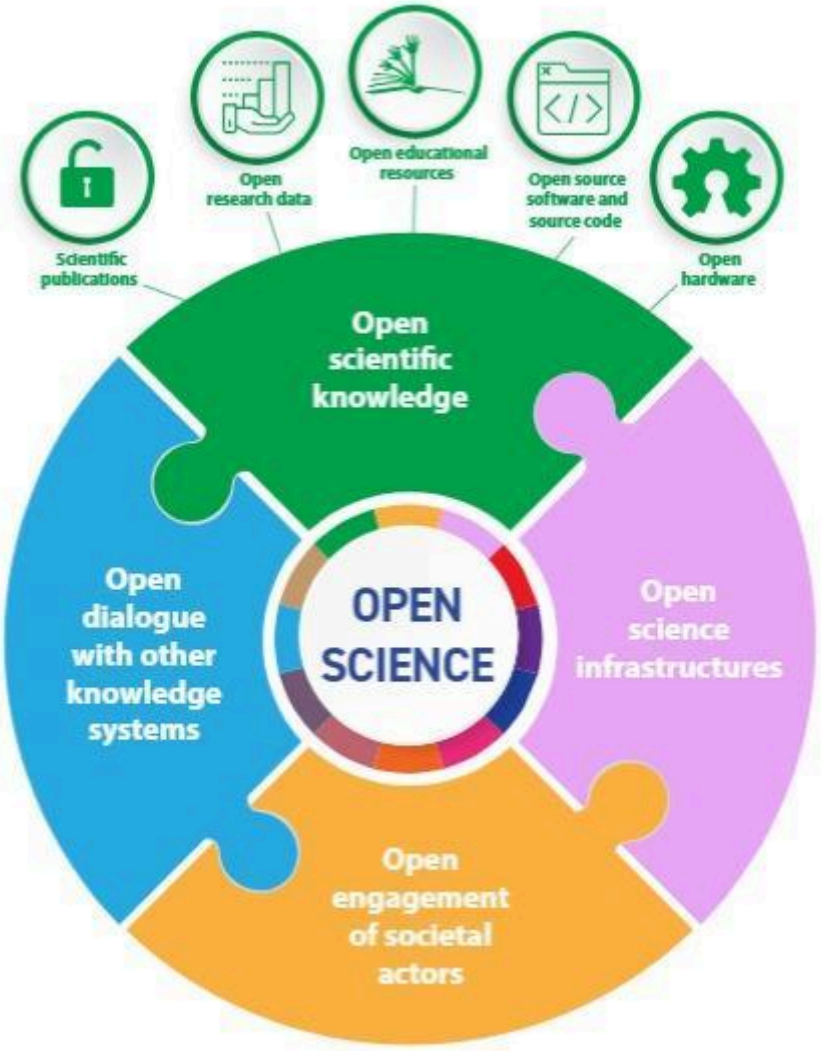
In this model, the Economic and Social Council seeks the active participation of each delegation researching important information and proposing viable solutions for all based on evidence, defending their points and questioning controversial issues with a diplomatic stance throughout the debate, bearing in mind that what is discussed will have repercussions throughout the world and for future generations. We, as a chair, expect each delegate to give their best and strive to change the world for the better.

This Council seeks to address this issue from a partial point of view, where the focus is not on the benefit of one country or company, but rather on the benefit of all, starting by recognizing the economic and social impact of the technological divide in order to know how to solve it, reviewing old inefficient actions to remodel, change, and improve them, starting from key points, it is important to recognize and understand the difference between innovation and hoarding knowledge. It should be clarified that all of this is in line with the United Nations' sustainable development goals.

The main concerns that the United Nations seeks to address are:

- In seeking solutions that take into account the 2030 Agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals, the United Nations has repeatedly emphasized that the objectives of these two points are alarmingly off track, as each country approaches them differently and other countries, due to different situations, are unable to focus on these points, which means that progress is too slow and the gap between developed and developing countries continues to widen.

- There are financing problems because each year there is a greater reduction than the previous year. For instance, in 2023 there was a reduction of 9 billion dollars, or 16% compared to the previous year. It is important to establish clear and realistic criteria for all countries around the world to be able to invest in weak areas. For this, international cooperation is also necessary, but even more so is cooperation between states and international financial institutions with specific development plans, especially for developing countries, in order to have more relevance on the world stage and achieve positive economic indicators.


Scientific publications
Open research data
Open educational resources
Open source software and source code
Open hardware
Open scientific knowledge
Open dialogue with other knowledge systems
OPEN SCIENCE
Open science infrastructures
Open engagement of societal actors

Conclusion

The Economic and Social Forum has provided sufficient information for delegates to understand this issue and express their country's position.

The Economic and Social Council has addressed the topic of "Overcoming Technology Segregation: Addressing Economic Inequality in the Access to Innovations" from a neutral point of view, and has provided you, as delegates, with enough context to form your own judgment on this issue. It is important to keep this in mind, as it will help you perform well in the debate.

As has been demonstrated, this topic focuses not only on the gap of development between countries or economical resources, and regulation, but also on human rights related to knowledge and structures that promote inequality.

While one of the objectives of the debate is to open the frontiers of knowledge by facilitating access to it for people with fewer resources, the importance of this issue goes beyond that. Society is affected by the abuse and selfishness that result from the hoarding of resources from other countries. When abuse and exploitation are pointed out, it is easier to find efficient alternatives and uncompromising measures.

During this edition of MUNIO, we, as a Chair, expect our delegates to give their best, to apply everything they will learn during this period in a responsible way, to follow the protocol and to participate in a conscious way, thus forming a strong and enjoyable working team.

We, as a Chair, hope to hear delegates' proposals that contribute to resolving this issue and, in turn, make it visible. All of this requires an open, supportive, and empathetic vision; a United Nations Model must advocate for equality for all people, and the dignity of everyone, not without any excuse. Thank you to all the delegates for choosing this committee and trusting the chair to lead the debate through this model.

"Innovation without inclusion, is just exclusion at scale."

Countries

Federative Republic of Brazil

The situation of Brazil combines ambitious public policies with marked inequalities. The Government has launched initiatives such as "Wifi Brazil" and "Computers for All", while NGOs such as Colab are building community networks in "favelas" and indigenous areas. However, the access to the internet in rural areas is delayed at 56%. Unlike public-private synergy in developed countries, Brazil's state efforts face market realities, although innovative as mandates require that 5G suppliers connect all schools.

People's Republic of China

The People's Republic of China is more focused on closing the internal digital divide in its country by bringing digital education programs, 5G technologies, and the Internet to rural and low-income areas, which has resulted in 99% of Chinese villages having Internet coverage.
From a global perspective. The People's Republic of China prioritizes autonomous development to reduce its dependence on the West, and thanks to projects such as "Made in China 2025," it will not be left behind in digital development.

Republic of India

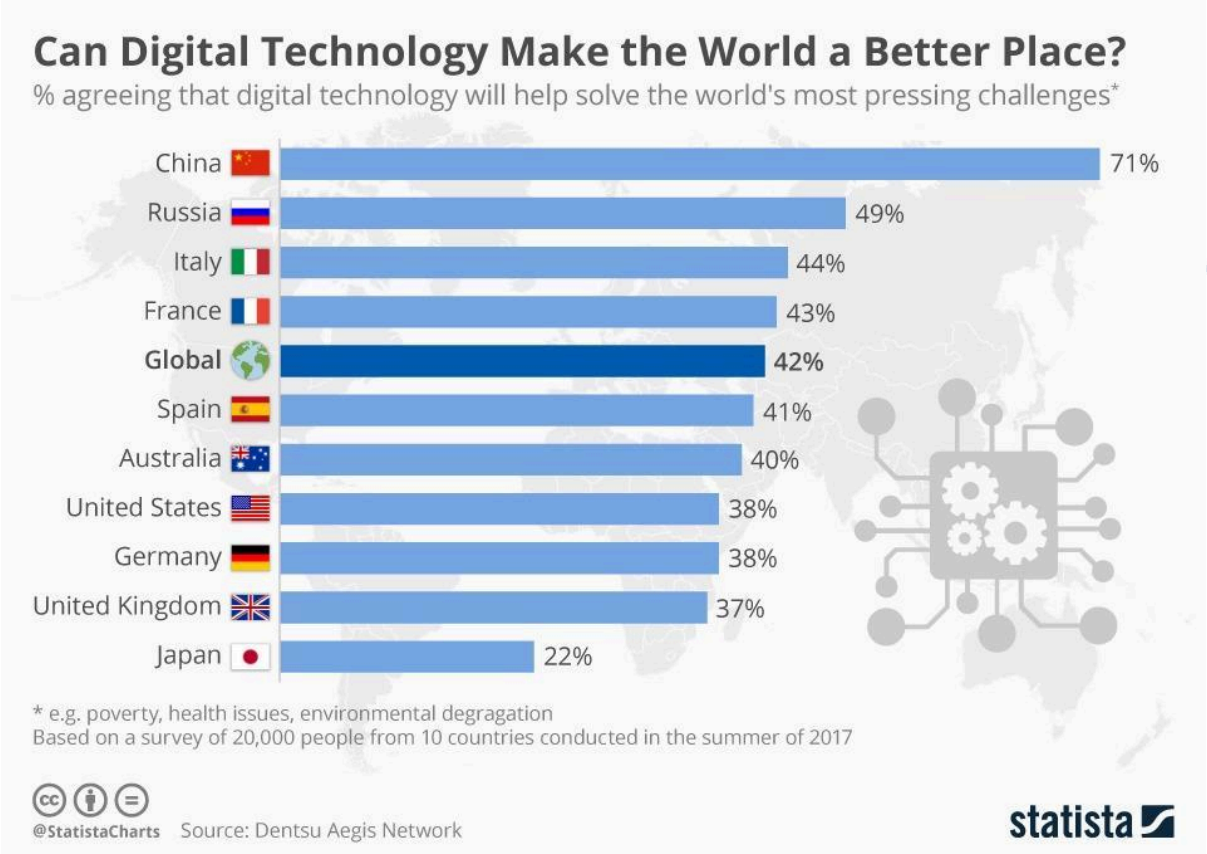
The Republic of India has emphasized its interest in cooperating internationally with countries in Asia, Africa, and Latin America, although it has been more neutral with more developed countries such as the United States of America. The Republic of India has developed technologies to close the internal gap and has emphasized the importance of educating new generations in the use of technology.

Republic of Korea

The Republic of Korea is promoting sustainable development through the digital transformation and innovation of AI. Aligning with the vision of the connectivity and progress of APEC 2025, it emphasizes technological advance as a path for shared prosperity. The country prioritizes key areas such as innovation, digital connectivity and cybersecurity, development generation is uniform and is ready for the future. It is also integrated into its economic strategy, as an objective to strengthen global collaboration while promoting long-term sustainability for all.

United States of America

The United States occupies a dominant position in the global patent system, leading high-value innovation, but with economic policies that encourage monopolies and promote patent laws favorable to corporations. Prioritizing profit and technological supremacy, inflating prices and hurting developing countries. The United States justifies this as protecting innovation, the affected nations argue that it prioritizes corporate control over public access, leaving smaller economies and consumers vulnerable to exploitation. Recent antitrust initiatives indicate awareness, but systemic reform remains constrained by entrenched corporate lobbying.



Countries in G5:

1. French Republic
2. People's Republic of China
3. Russian Federation
4. United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
5. United States of America

Non-permanent members:

6. **African States:** Republic of Mozambique
7. **Asia-Pacific States:** Turkmenistan
8. **Eastern European States:** Republic of Croatia
9. **Latin American and Caribbean States:** Republic of Peru
10. **Other:** Federal Republic of Germany
11. **Western European and Other States:** Republic of Finland

Countries invited to the debate and listening countries:

12. Argentine Republic
13. Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela
14. Canada
15. Commonwealth of Australia
16. Democratic People's Republic of Korea
17. Democratic Republic of the Congo
18. Federative Republic of Brazil
19. Federative Republic of Nigeria
20. Islamic Republic of Iran
21. Japan
22. Republic of Cuba
23. Republic of India
24. Republic of Korea
25. Republic of the Philippines
26. Republic of Singapore
27. Republic of South Africa
28. State of Israel
29. Ukraine

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"Those who believe in the world are the ones meant to change it".

President: Carlos Arredondo Tlalleca
Secretary: César de la Vega Alonso
Moderator: Armando Vázquez Ortega

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